

WHAT IS ART?

Time has changed the definition of art. In the ancient past, handcrafted objects were not perceived as art, nor was the creator considered an artist. Over the centuries, the notion of the artist has developed, along with a broad range of artistic styles. From paintings and sculptures to photography and architecture, today's art challenges traditional thought. Expression and imagination allow artists to break new—and sometimes controversial—ground.

ARTISTIC INTERPRETATION

With artists becoming ever more creative and expressive, the perceptions of what art is has become very contentious. In defining art, a line must be drawn somewhere, but the decision is up to the individual. The desk you sit at was designed and produced by someone. The clothes you wear were designed and manufactured by another. The book you are reading was designed and written by someone. The list of examples is endless. While some would interpret these things as art, others would dismiss them as functional items, instead claiming that true art must be in a traditional form, such as a painting or sculpture. So, where do you draw the line?

CHANGING VALUES

Art competitions attract a range of weird and wonderful entries. The U.K.'s Turner Prize famously goes against traditional concepts of art, displaying flashing lights, preserved sharks, and unmade beds. However, it is not only the type of art on display that has changed beyond recognition. The value attached to different works has rocketed with time. In 1990, a painting by Dutch artist Vincent van Gogh (1853–1890) sold for about \$78 million, though in his lifetime he could not make a living from his work.

